DRIVER AIRBAG (Continued)

proper electrical signal to the initiator the electrical energy generates enough heat to initiate a small pyrotechnic charge which, in turn ignites chemical pellets within the inflator. Once ignited, these chemical pellets burn rapidly and produce a large quantity of inert gas. The inflator is sealed to the back of the airbag housing and a diffuser in the inflator directs all of the inert gas into the airbag cushion, causing the cushion to inflate. As the cushion inflates, the driver airbag trim cover will split at predetermined breakout lines, then fold back out of the way along with the horn switch unit. Following an airbag deployment, the airbag cushion quickly deflates by venting the inert gas towards the instrument panel through the porous fabric material used to construct the back (steering wheel side) panel of the airbag cushion.

Some of the chemicals used to create the inert gas may be considered hazardous while in their solid state before they are burned, but they are securely sealed within the airbag inflator. Typically, all potentially hazardous chemicals are burned during an airbag deployment event. The inert gas that is produced when the chemicals are burned is harmless. However, a small amount of residue from the burned chemicals may cause some temporary discomfort if it contacts the skin, eyes, or breathing passages. If skin or eye irritation is noted, rinse the affected area with plenty of cool, clean water. If breathing passages are irritated, move to another area where there is plenty of clean, fresh air to breath. If the irritation is not alleviated by these actions, contact a physician.

REMOVAL

The following procedure is for replacement of a faulty or damaged driver airbag. If the airbag is faulty or damaged, but not deployed, review the recommended procedures for handling non-deployed supplemental restraints. (Refer to 8 - ELECTRICAL/ RESTRAINTS - STANDARD PROCEDURE - HANDLING NON-DEPLOYED SUPPLEMENTAL RESTRAINTS). If the driver airbag has been deployed, review the recommended procedures for service after a supplemental restraint deployment before removing the airbag from the vehicle. (Refer to 8 - ELECTRICAL/RESTRAINTS - STANDARD PROCEDURE - SERVICE AFTER A SUPPLEMENTAL RESTRAINT DEPLOYMENT).

WARNING: TO AVOID PERSONAL INJURY OR DEATH, ON VEHICLES EQUIPPED WITH AIRBAGS, DISABLE THE SUPPLEMENTAL RESTRAINT SYSTEM BEFORE ATTEMPTING ANY STEERING WHEEL, STEERING COLUMN, AIRBAG, OR INSTRUMENT PANEL COMPONENT DIAGNOSIS OR SERVICE. DISCONNECT AND ISOLATE THE BATTERY NEGATIVE (GROUND) CABLE, THEN WAIT TWO MINUTES FOR THE SYSTEM CAPACITOR TO DISCHARGE BEFORE PERFORMING FURTHER DIAGNOSIS OR SERVICE. THIS IS THE ONLY SURE WAY TO DISABLE THE SUPPLEMENTAL RESTRAINT SYSTEM. FAILURE TO TAKE THE PROPER PRECAUTIONS COULD RESULT IN ACCIDENTAL AIRBAG DEPLOYMENT.

WARNING: TO AVOID PERSONAL INJURY OR DEATH, WHEN REMOVING A DEPLOYED AIRBAG, RUBBER GLOVES, EYE PROTECTION, AND A LONG-SLEEVED SHIRT SHOULD BE WORN. THERE MAY BE DEPOSITS ON THE AIRBAG CUSHION AND OTHER INTERIOR SURFACES. IN LARGE DOSES, THESE DEPOSITS MAY CAUSE IRRITATION TO THE SKIN AND EYES.

(1) Disconnect and isolate the battery negative cable. Wait two minutes for the system capacitor to discharge before further service.

(2) From the underside of the steering wheel, remove the two screws that secure the driver airbag to the steering wheel armature (Fig. 22).

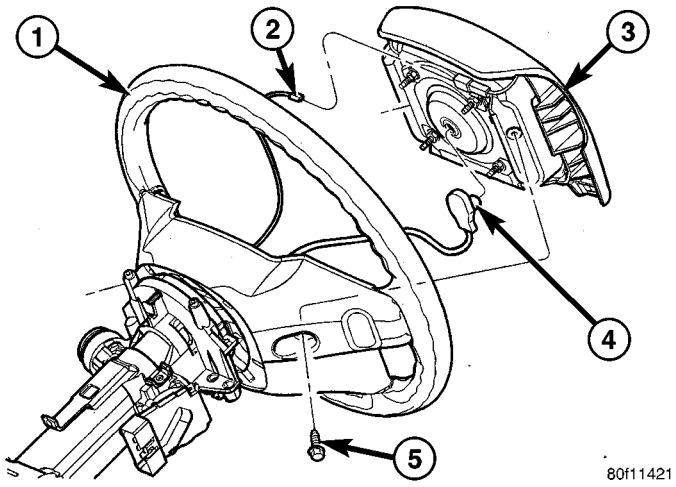

Fig. 22 Driver Airbag Remove/Install

1 - STEERING WHEEL
2 - CLOCKSPRING PIGTAIL WIRE (HORN SWITCH)
3 - DRIVER AIRBAG
4 - CLOCKSPRING PIGTAIL WIRE (AIRBAG)
5 - SCREW (2)

(3) Pull the driver airbag away from the steering wheel far enough to access the two electrical connections at the back of the airbag housing.

(4) Disconnect the clockspring pigtail wire connector for the horn switch from the horn switch feed pigtail wire connector located on the back of the driver airbag.